MIND OVER MATTER

For many years, sports physiologists were convinced that no-one could run a mile in less than four minutes. However, a talented runner, Roger Bannister, was determined to prove them wrong. He trained his body so that he could run his fastest—but he also trained his mind, focusing on the idea that he could break the four-minute barrier. On 6 May, 1954, he did just that. Once Bannister had shown that the four-minute barrier could be broken, other runners found that they could break it too. The barrier had been as much a mental as a physical one. The following year more than 300 runners ran the mile in under four minutes.

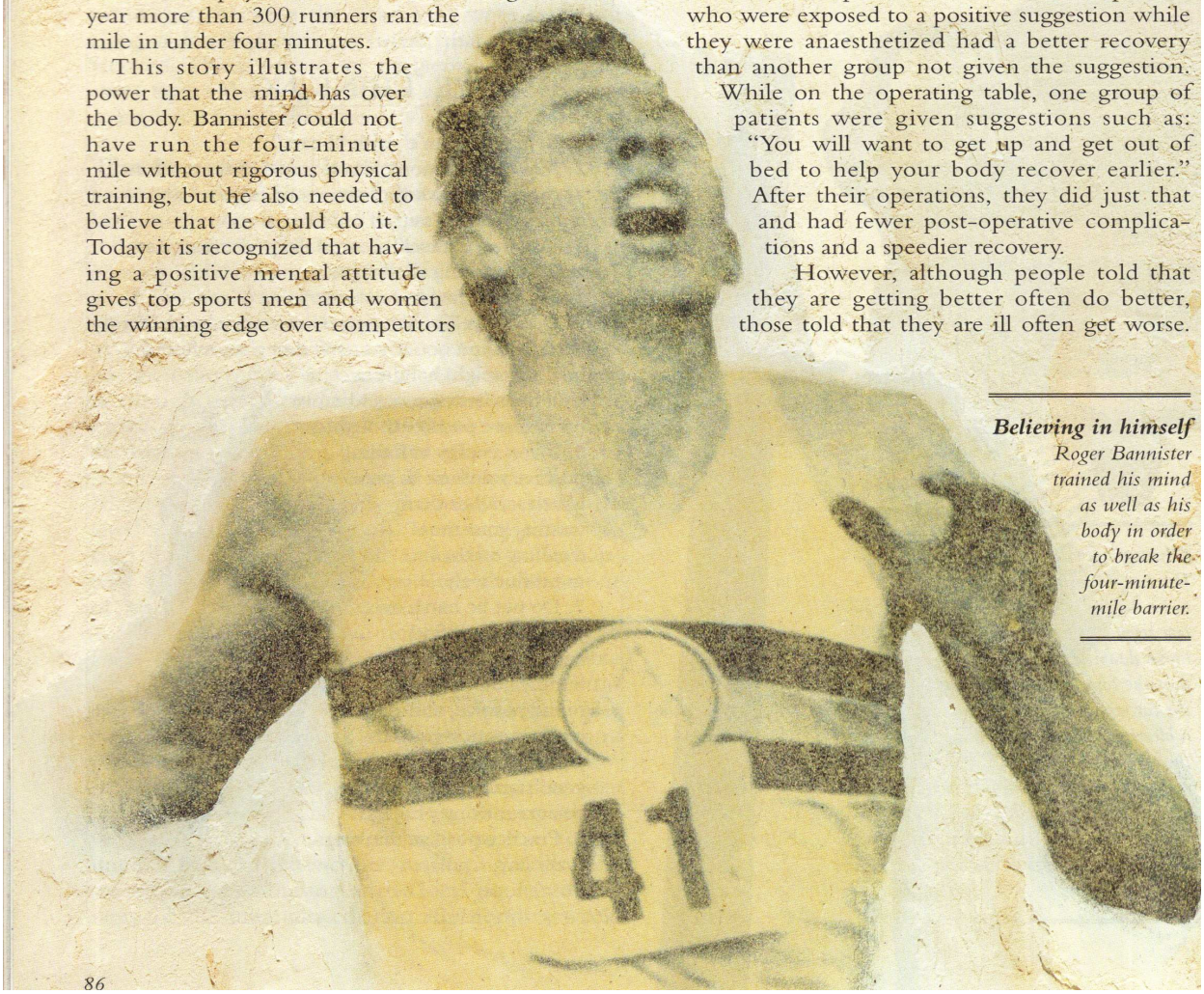
This story illustrates the power that the mind has over the body. Bannister could not have run the four-minute mile without rigorous physical training, but he also needed to believe that he could do it. Today it is recognized that having a positive mental attitude gives top sports men and women the winning edge over competitors with equal physical skills, and many competitors practice relaxation and visualization techniques before competing.

Believing that you can do something is important in many fields other than sports. For people in all walks of life and all states of physical fitness, the mind has a powerful impact on the body.

Healthy mind, healthy body

In one study reported in the influential British medical journal, *The Lancet*, Dr. Carlton Evans of St. Thomas's Hospital, London found that patients who were exposed to a positive suggestion while they were anaesthetized had a better recovery than another group not given the suggestion. While on the operating table, one group of patients were given suggestions such as: "You will want to get up and get out of bed to help your body recover earlier." After their operations, they did just that and had fewer post-operative complications and a speedier recovery.

However, although people told that they are getting better often do better, those told that they are ill often get worse.



Believing in himself
Roger Bannister trained his mind as well as his body in order to break the four-minute-mile barrier.

Reference:

Mind Power, **Maximise your Performance**. Time-Life Books, Europe Edition (1995).